

32 Past tenses

A Last year we began a study of airbags on our four wheel drive vehicles. First we analysed the results of the tests that we had carried out. After the results had been compiled, we used modelling software to evaluate the performance of the airbags. This showed how well they had performed under different conditions. While we were evaluating the physical performance, another study was assessing the materials that we were using. All the results were then recorded into a database.

B Form

Past simple and Past continuous

	Positive	Negative	Question
Past simple active	Last year we <i>began</i> a new study.	We <i>didn't develop</i> the software ourselves.	Where <i>did</i> you <i>record</i> the results?
Past simple passive	The performance of the air bags <i>was assessed</i> .	The results <i>weren't recorded</i> .	Where <i>were</i> the findings <i>published</i> ?
Past continuous active	While the analyst <i>was carrying</i> out the test ...	... the other technicians <i>were not recording</i> the results.	What <i>were</i> you <i>doing</i> during the test phase?
Past continuous passive	While the test <i>was being</i> carried out ...	... the results <i>were not being</i> recorded.	Why <i>were</i> the findings <i>being written</i> down?

Past perfect

	Positive	Negative	Question
Past perfect simple active	After we <i>had compiled</i> the results ...	Because they <i>had not recorded</i> the data ...	<i>Had</i> they <i>carried out</i> all the tests?
Past perfect simple passive	... after the results <i>had been compiled</i> .	... because the data <i>had not been recorded</i> .	<i>Had</i> all the tests <i>been carried out</i> ?
Past perfect continuous active	The analyst <i>had been checking</i> the walls yesterday ...	We <i>had not been evaluating</i> the physical characteristics ...	How long <i>had</i> you <i>been working</i> on the project?

Note: the *past perfect continuous active* is quite unusual and the *past perfect continuous passive* is very rare

C Uses

All the *past tenses* are used to express activities at a definite time in the past.

The *past simple* describes:

an activity at a definite time in the past

The study of airbags was started last year.

The *past continuous* describes:

an activity which is a time frame for another activity

While we were studying the airbags, we made a significant discovery.

While our team was studying performance, another team was looking at the characteristics.

The *past perfect* describes:

an activity that happened earlier than another activity in the past

Our studies showed how well the equipment had performed.

Notes:

We use the *past tenses* with these expressions:

yesterday **yesterday** morning/afternoon,/evening

last **last** night/week/month/year

ago **one hour/two weeks/three months/four years ago**

in **in** 2005/the 1990's/the 19th century

TASKS

1 Six of the following sentences contain mistakes. Find the mistakes and correct them.

- 1 Sydney Harbour Bridge was building in 1932.
- 2 While they were carrying out tests in the laboratories, researchers were analysing past results.
- 3 The first real road builders in Britain was the Romans.
- 4 The Romans built roads of layers of broken stones of various sizes and were covering them with flat stones.
- 5 The system didn't working because the loudspeaker had been wrongly connected.
- 6 Before factories were told to stop polluting the environment, waste was being dumped in rivers and in the sea.
- 7 Louis Pasteur was discovering the action of germs while he was studying fermentation in wines.
- 8 The production process had already been shut down when the leak in the fuel tank was found.
- 9 Nuclear energy began to be used from the mid-1950s.
- 10 In the second half of the 20th century, the electronics industry transforming the way we work in factories.

2 Make past tense questions and answers using the words given.

1: When were fibre optics first developed?

- 1 When / be / fibre optics / first / develop?
- 2 The boxes / break / because they / make / of low quality materials.
- 3 The power supply / cut off / because / cables / come down / during the storm.
- 4 They / not complete / the foundations / by the time the building materials / arrive.
- 5 When / they / install / the solar panels?
- 6 be / this / the first hydroelectric scheme/ in Scotland?
- 7 They / not use / wood chip / for heating / when the engineer / visit / the factory.
- 8 How / they / produce / gas / before they / discover / North Sea gas?
- 9 be / the oil pollution along the coastline / cause / by an oil tanker spillage?
- 10 How / they prepare access to this mine?

3 Complete the following report of an accident which happened in a factory with the correct form of the verbs in brackets.

On Friday morning at 9.25 a worker in the chemical plant (a) _____ (find) by a female colleague. He (b) _____ (lie) on the floor. His colleague (c) _____ (check) that he (d) _____ still _____ (breathe) and then (e) _____ (call) the emergency services. The injured man (f) _____ (take) to hospital where he later (g) _____ (recover). An investigation at the factory (h) _____ (find) that a bottle containing a dangerous chemical liquid (i) _____ (leave) open. Vapour from the liquid (j) _____ (escape) into the air. While he had been working in the room he (k) _____ (become) unwell. He (l) _____ (become) drowsy and then (m) _____ (fall) unconscious. Investigating officers are interviewing everyone who (n) _____ (work) in the factory that morning.